

Arctic seals

Icy Arctic seas are home to many types of seals. Most are true seals, with back-pointing hind limbs and short flippers that are useless on land, but perfect for driving the seal through water. The fur seals, sea lions, and walrus have longer front flippers and are able to turn their hind limbs forward, so they are more mobile on land.



Bearded seal

Touch sensitive

Length Up to 8 ft (2.4 m)

Weight Up to 794 lb (360 kg)

Habitat Coastal seas

Like the walrus, the bearded seal finds most of its prey on the seabed, locating it by touch using its very long, sensitive whiskers. It feeds on clams and crabs, as well as squid and seafloor fish. This hunting technique limits the seal to shallow coastal water, but it lives all around the Arctic Ocean and nearby seas. Females give birth alone on small ice floes; unusually, the pups are able to swim and dive within a few hours of being born.

Walrus

Tusked giant

Length Male up to 10 ft (3 m)

Weight Male up to 2,670 lb (1,210 kg)

Habitat Coastal seas

The walrus is much bigger than other seals and not closely related to any of them, although it is built like an oversized sea lion. It lives all around the Arctic on rocky coasts, hunting for clams and other shellfish on the shallow seabed. Its most obvious feature is its long tusks, which

are extended upper canine teeth and can grow up to 3 ft (90 cm) long. Both males and the smaller females have these. They sometimes use them for fighting, as well as for hauling themselves out of the water and on to the ice, but they are mainly a symbol of age and social importance.

▼ BASKING WALRUSES

Walruses are very sociable and often gather in tightly packed groups to warm up after diving for food in the cold water.

